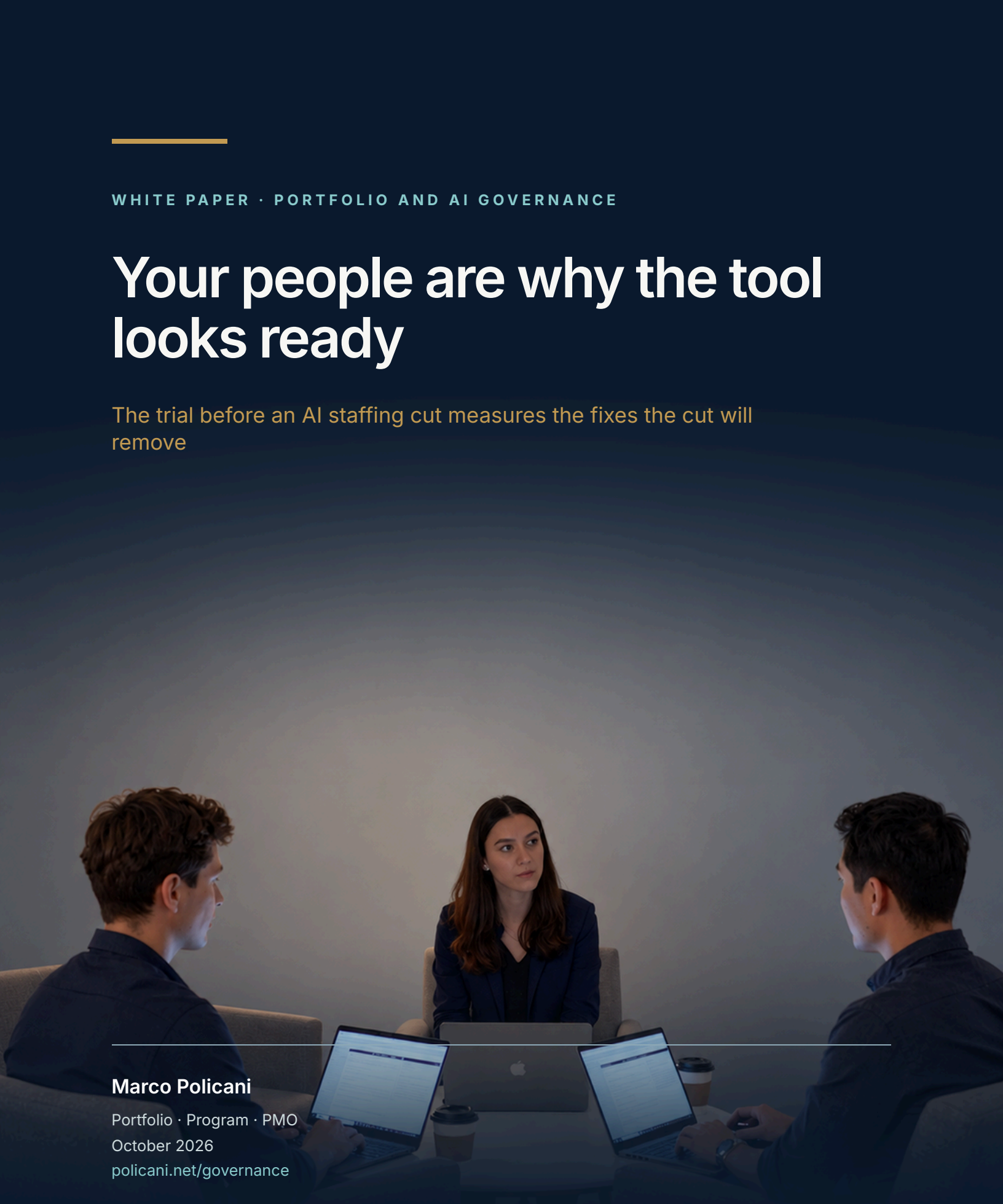
WHITE PAPER · PORTFOLIO AND AI GOVERNANCE

Your people are why the tool looks ready

The trial before an AI staffing cut measures the fixes the cut will remove



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THE CENTRAL ARGUMENT

An AI tool drafts work your staff review and send. The trial you run before reducing roles counts the tool and your people's fixes together. And those fixes often leave no record. Reducing the roles removes the fixes. So the tool's own error rate shows only after the people catching its mistakes are gone. Before you decide, save each draft before anyone edits it and compare it with what was sent. Then have someone who did not edit the drafts judge a sample against pass criteria written down first.

A tool now drafts work your people used to write: replies to customers, claim summaries, first reviews of documents. Your staff read each draft, fix what needs fixing and send it. After a few months the figures look good. Errors are low, complaints are flat and the quality team's samples pass. The next question is whether you still need as many people in those roles.

Those figures measure the tool and your people together. Someone rewrites a wrong sentence or adds a missing step before sending. Each time, the work leaves their desk looking right, and the record shows the tool's draft as sent. Reduce the roles and you remove those fixes. The tool's own error rate shows up only after the people who were catching its mistakes are gone.

You can see that error rate before you decide, and it costs little. Save each draft before anyone edits it. Compare it with what was sent. And judge the drafts against pass criteria you write down now.

ARGUMENT AT A GLANCE

What the trial counts, and what to check instead

The trial

Counts the tool plus the fixes staff make before work is sent.

The reduction

Removes the fixes, so the tool's own errors show up later.

The check

Save drafts before editing; judge a sample against pass criteria set first.

Applies where staff review or edit the tool's drafts and those edits are not recorded.

What the trial counts

Most sponsors already know the warnings. A role holds more than its task list. Rory Sutherland's name for forgetting this is the doorman fallacy. Cuts are hard to undo. A tool should prove itself in real work before roles change. So you run a trial with the people still in place and watch the numbers. That is the right instinct. The trouble is in what reaches the numbers.

Older automation made this easy to see. When it could not handle a case, it passed the case to a person, and the system counted the handoff. Step-in rates come from those counts. A drafting tool works differently. It hands every case to a person. When that person edits the draft in place, often nothing records the edit. The record shows a draft produced and a reply sent. The tool and your people make one piece of work together, and there is no separate tool result to look at.

Skilled people fix problems quietly. Anita Tucker and Amy Edmondson spent 239 hours watching 26 nurses at nine hospitals, most of which were chosen for excellent nursing [1]. The nurses met problems all the time: missing supplies, wrong information, broken equipment. For 93 percent of those problems, the nurse did what it took to keep caring for the patient and moved on. In those cases, the nurse did not tell anyone who could fix the cause. The nurses felt good about this. Fixing things on the spot felt like doing the job well. And 70 percent of the nurses interviewed believed their managers expected them to cope on their own. The hospitals' records showed work running smoothly, without the failures the nurses kept fixing. The authors called that calm "illusory."

Those nurses were not checking a software tool, and their jobs were not at stake. What carries over is how good people treat a failure. They fix it where it lands, and a fix that no one writes down never reaches the record. In a trial that will decide staffing, people may do the opposite and make their fixes loud, to show they are needed. Either way, fixes you did not capture cannot tell you how the tool performs.

So the trial's error rate is not the tool's. It is the rate of errors that got past your staff. The quality team's sample does not change this, because it checks finished work, after the fixes. None of this means your staff are hiding anything. Their care is why the trial looks clean, and that care is part of what you are measuring. If drafts went straight to customers with no one reviewing them, the trial would measure the tool alone. If every change is already logged, the problem is limited to the edits that are not.

What happens when the roles go

The mistakes the departing people used to catch are no longer caught at their desks. Where those mistakes surface is harder to say. The likely places are later and somewhere else: in customer complaints, in another team's rework, in a step further

down the line. There they are hard to trace back to the tool. Both points are reasoning from how the work flows, not a measured pattern.

The same reasoning applies to a gentler path. If roles are lost through attrition or a hiring pause, the same loss of fixes happens slowly. The people who remain take on more of the unusual cases. They put some off and pass others along. Work that needs judgment piles up, or errors build on earlier errors, before anyone sees a pattern. Tucker and Edmondson describe a similar slow cost: fixing failures takes time, and over time it wears people out [1].

A cut is the hardest to undo. Wayne Cascio studied downsizing in large US firms, before today's AI. In his studies, firms that cut headcount without other changes lost knowledge and client relationships [2]. They had to recruit and train again when work came back [2]. Attrition and a hiring pause are easier to reverse, because you can hire again.

Under the usual trial, though, the figure you need arrives after the decision. That figure is the tool's error rate without people fixing it. For a cut, it arrives when undoing the cut is costly. For a slow reduction, it arrives late and in pieces, after the errors have built up. You cannot find the answer by reducing the roles and watching. The evidence has to exist first.

Seeing the tool on its own

The tool's own performance shows only in work no one has repaired, judged against a standard you have agreed on. You can get that without doing any case twice. Save each draft the moment the tool produces it, before anyone touches it. Then compare it with what was finally sent. The differences are the fixes: how often staff changed a draft and what they changed. Also record how long each draft took to review and fix, including the drafts that needed nothing.

Asking staff to log their own fixes is a start. But it is not enough, because people working with a tool miss some of its errors. Fabrizio Dell'Acqua and colleagues ran a randomized experiment with 758 consultants, some using GPT-4 [3]. On a set of realistic tasks, the consultants with the tool did better than those without it. A separate group of consultants got a business problem designed to fall outside what the tool did well. There, the tool users were less often correct. About 85 percent of those without the tool got the right answer, against 60 and 71 percent in the two groups that had it.

Graders who did not know the right answer rated the tool users' work as clearer and more persuasive, whether it was right or not. The errors could be counted because the problem had one correct answer. And the harm showed only because a randomly chosen group worked without the tool. The authors read this as a line between kinds of tasks that is hard to see from inside the work. Two tasks can look alike on paper and respond to the same tool in opposite ways.

That study compared people with and without the tool. It did not test the tool alone. The consultants were early in their careers, and the authors say results may differ for more experienced people. The saved-draft check builds on the study's two lessons. Some errors get past the people using the tool, especially when the wrong work reads well. And an error can be counted only against a standard. Comparing each draft with what was sent shows what your staff fixed. Judging the raw drafts against the standard catches what they missed.

Set the pass criteria first

Write down the pass criteria, and how you will choose the cases, before anyone's job depends on the result. Once it does, everyone has a stake. You have a saving to book, and your staff have their roles. Each side has a reason to read a close result its own way. And a standard chosen after the results can be fitted to them. Dell'Acqua's team fixed their plan for the analysis before they saw any results [3]. The same habit works here.

Take the cases from the real mix of work, including the unusual ones, not from cases picked because they look typical.

With the criteria fixed, the evidence can answer the staffing question for each kind of work. Where you would remove the review step entirely, the raw drafts must meet the standard on their own. Where you would keep fewer reviewers, the time to read every draft and make the measured fixes must fit the people who remain. Where neither holds, people stay with that work, or the tool takes a smaller share of it.

This does not settle the whole decision. A role still holds work the tool never touched, and that has to be weighed as well. The saved drafts settle the part the usual trial cannot: what the tool leaves behind when the people who were fixing it are gone.

Before the decision

Saving drafts before they are edited means keeping a copy of each one before review. The real cost is someone's time to judge a sample of drafts against the criteria. That is small next to a reduction that is hard to reverse or slow to show its cost.

Before you look at any more results, write down three things: the pass criteria, how the cases will be sampled and the date the decision will be made. Have the team running the tool save every draft and record how long each one took to review and fix. Before the decision date, have someone who did not edit the drafts judge a sample of them against the criteria. On the decision date, decide each kind of work on what the drafts show, not on how calm the trial looked.

Sources

1. Anita L. Tucker and Amy C. Edmondson, California Management Review. Why Hospitals Don't Learn from Failures: Organizational and Psychological Dynamics that Inhibit System Change (2003).
2. Wayne F. Cascio, SHRM Foundation. Employment Downsizing and Its Alternatives (2009).
3. Fabrizio Dell'Acqua and colleagues, Organization Science. Navigating the Jagged Technological Frontier (2026).